ran as fast as I could. Little but quick steps, and careful manoeuvring through the crowd of students streaming into the corridor took me out of the classroom building to the playground. I locked my sights on my target. I made a run for it. There was nobody to contest it when I reached and occupied my seat on the tyre swing. It took me a while to catch my breath. But I was happy. *Dada would be so proud*. Ten minutes later, another bell rang. Recess for the students in the first grade had commenced. For Upper KG and below, recess started much earlier. That is why Dada had charged me with the task of keeping the tyre swing occupied till he came around. That swing was a favourite with all the senior boys. Many came running towards it, returning disappointed on hearing me say, 'It's for my Dada; you go away.' Finally, Dada let me play with his friends when he came to see that I'd done the task he had asked me to do.

I continued this for a couple of days. Together, Dada and I had devised a plan that suited both of us. He got the tyre swing and I got his friends. This, however, didn't sit well with some of the boys. Hostility brewed among the senior-most of them. Mutiny was imminent. 'Gunjan from KG' became a notorious figure on the playground premises. Consequently, things took a bad turn one day.

'Give me the tyre,' a burly sardar boy of the second standard stood in front of me as I sat on the tyre swing that day. 'No,' I replied grimly, 'I'll only give it to Dada.'

'Give it to me or I'll teach you and your Dada a lesson today,' he took a step forward, with hands on his waist as he warned me. A frown appeared on his round face. His red *patka* screened the sun and his shadow fell on me. Terrified but resolute, I replied, 'I will not give it to you.' From the corner of my eyes I saw two other boys join him to his left and right. Scared, I buried my neck in my sweater.

'I'm asking you one last time,' he said.

I desperately hoped for Dada to show up. But I was not going to give up. 'Only my Dada will get the swing.' Even as I said this, I tightened my grip on the ropes of the swing. The sardar boy came closer and tugged at my arm. The tiffin fell from my lap and on to the ground, its contents scattered